

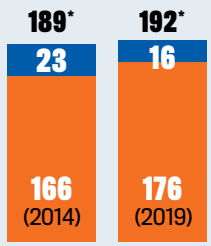
Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

The obituary has been long in the writing, dusted off every time the Congress loses another election. Now, however, the possibility of the grand old party disappearing into oblivion has become very real. Impervious to that idea so far, the realisation is finally dawning on the Congress—that it may be on the cusp of extinction if it does not take immediate steps to avert its demise. Hence a 'Nava Sankalpa Shivir', a three-day brainstorming session in Rajasthan's Udaipur from May 13 to 15. It's the fourth such conclave since 1998, but the last one was held way back in 2013, a year before the party delivered its worst Lok Sabha performance. More than 400 Congress delegates will gather here to urgently debate strategies to combat the immediate challenges—assembly elections in 10 states in the next two years—before gearing up for the 2024 general election. These states account for 144 of the Lok Sabha's 543 seats, of which the Congress currently has just nine. Even though it won assembly elections in three of these states the last time, it lost the government in one—Madhya Pradesh—to internal feuds, a challenge that has reared its head in two other states—Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—as well.

The Congress now finds itself in the deepest electoral abyss it has ever faced. Its Lok Sabha tally is at a historic low—44 in 2014 and 52 in 2019. Its national vote share has plummeted to 19 per cent from its 50-year peak of 49.1 per cent in the 1984 general election. Of the 30 states (including Delhi and Puducherry) in the country, it is in power only in two—Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—and is a minor coalition partner in two others: Maharashtra and Jharkhand. The party has lost 37 of the 50 assembly elections in the past eight years. But its problems today are not just electoral. As senior leader Manish Tewari tells INDIA TODAY, "Every political party requires five fundamentals that are moving parts but have to work in cohesion to ensure electoral and national relevance—ideology, narrative, organisation, access to resources and leadership. All these variables need to come together for the net power of that organisation to demonstrate electoral efficacy. All five today are a

WINDOWS OF OPPORTUNITY

The challenge for the Congress is to win seats where it was second in 2019, particularly against the BJP



*Seats where Congress was in direct contest with BJP (the two parties were either first or second)

Won by Congress Won by BJP

SEATS WHERE CONGRESS WAS RUNNERS-UP



(the contest was either against BJP or another party)

- In 125 seats, it lost by over **15%** votes
- In 54 seats, it lost by **5-15%** votes
- In 17 seats, it lost by a margin of less than **5%**